

Space Empires: Imperium

A two-player Traveller-era campaign game

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[1.0] INTRODUCTION

In 2113 the expanding Terran Confederation reaches the edge of the Ziru Sirka, the First Imperium. Neither polity can accept the other's idea of order. What begins as a frontier dispute becomes a succession of short, violent wars separated by uneasy peaces. Terra learns quickly; the Imperial provincial governor commands greater resources but must answer to a distant Emperor.

Space Empires: Imperium is a two-player strategic campaign. It keeps the point-to-point jump map, political asymmetry, Glory system, and repeated wars of GDW's *Imperium*. It uses the ship groups, firing classes, attack and defense values, hull damage, screening, fighters, and ground forces from *Space Empires: 4X* and *Close Encounters*. A shared card deck introduces a small amount of operational surprise.

Fleet combat specifically reconciles the two parent systems rather than discarding either one. Fleets contest Long or Close Range and choose beam, missile, or mixed armament in the manner of *Imperium*, while attacks use the printed classes, d10 Hit Numbers, screening, and hull damage of *Space Empires: 4X*. Traveller-inspired pickets, point defense, and sandcasters make the range and weapon choices visible at fleet scale.

This is an alpha playtest design. Its systems are complete enough to play the *First Shots* war, but the force mix and economy have not yet been balanced through repeated play.

[1.1] The Central Design Choice

The game is not a full 4X game. The map is known, the frontier is already settled, and there are no non-player aliens. Players fight over an existing political geography. Technology changes slowly and only between wars. The interesting decisions should be where to build a logistics chain, whether to hold missile range or close to beam range, when to commit the fleet, whether to risk an invasion before orbital combat is settled, and how much political capital to spend for a short-term advantage.

[1.2] Rules Hierarchy

Use these rules first. If they do not address a situation, use the following sources in order:

1. this rulebook and the text in its card manifest;
2. *Space Empires: 4X* rules for ships, groups, damage, screening, fighters, and retreat;
3. *Close Encounters* section 14 for transports and ground combat; and
4. *Imperium* only for interpretation of its map and named systems.

Rules from a parent game that concern hex movement, exploration, colony growth, aliens, or that game's sequence of play do not apply. When printed card text disagrees with the manifest in this rulebook, the manifest controls.

[1.3] Rounding and Dice

Round fractions down unless a rule says otherwise. A "die" or "d10" is a ten-sided die; a zero face counts as 10. "2d6" means two six-sided dice added together.

[2.0] GAME PARTS

[2.1] Required Material

You need the map and charts from *Imperium*; ship, group, numeral, technology, damage, colony, Base, and resource markers from *Space Empires: 4X*; and Transport and Ground Unit counters from *Close Encounters*. You also need the 42-card Imperium Deck in the Cards directory, two d6, several d10, and spare markers for missile depletion and defensive reactions.

The original *Imperium* ship and troop counters are not used. Its World and Outpost counters may be used if they are easier to read than the substitutions below.

[2.2] Map Terms

A **system** is a named stellar hex and every planetary surface box attached to it. A green line joining two stellar hexes is a **jump route**; the joined systems are **adjacent**. Ordinary map hexes and sublight movement are ignored.

A **primary surface** is a white planetary surface box. A **secondary surface** is a red box. A binary system can contain two surfaces with different owners. Space control is determined once for the whole stellar hex, while surface control is determined separately for each box.

[2.3] Counter Substitutions

Game term	Counter used
World	5 Colony marker; use a Home marker at Sol and Gashidda
Outpost	1 Colony marker
Neutralized	3 Colony or spare status marker on a World
Planetary Defense	Base
Fleet Train	MS Pipeline
Resource Units	CP markers and track

Worlds and Outposts do not grow like *Space Empires: 4X* colonies. The number on their substitute counter is only a reminder of their defensive Militia value.

[2.4] Units in Use

The initial design uses Scouts (SC), Destroyers (DD), Cruisers (CA), Battlecruisers (BC), Battleships (BB), Dreadnoughts (DN), Carriers (CV), Fighters (F), Bases, Transports (TR), and the Ground Units described in these rules. Their printed class, attack, defense, and hull values are unchanged.

Colony Ships, Miners, Raiders, Mines, Minesweepers, Ship Yards, Titans, alien ships, and non-player forces are not used. The Minefield card does not require a Mine counter.

[2.5] Groups and Stacks

Use *Space Empires: 4X* group and numeral rules. A **group** contains one ship type with identical technology and, where applicable, one Armament Package. A **stack** is every friendly group that moves together from one system. Ground Units and Fighters being carried move with their Transport or Carrier but do not count as separate groups.

Groups stay face down on the map. Reveal them when required by combat or an event, then conceal surviving groups after all combat in that system ends.

[2.6] Resource Units

Resource Units (RU) replace Colony Points. One RU equals one CP for every printed *Space Empires: 4X* cost. RU may be saved without limit between turns and, in a campaign, between wars.

[3.0] GENERAL SETUP

1. Choose a scenario and sides. Terra uses one *Space Empires: 4X* color and the Imperium another.
2. Lay out the *Imperium* map. Place Worlds, Outposts, Bases, fleets, and Ground Units listed by the scenario. Put Ground Units and Bases in their surface box; all other starting units begin in the stellar hex.
3. Record each side's starting technology and capital-construction level, and record an Armament Package for every eligible ship group. Technology applies to every eligible friendly group.
4. Put the Terran Turn marker at 0, the Imperial Turn marker at 11, and the Glory marker at 5. Put the Game Turn marker at 1.
5. Put each RU marker at the scenario's starting amount. The first scenario begins with 0 RU.
6. Shuffle the Imperium Deck. Deal the starting hands specified in section 12.
7. Place purchased-unit counters, damage markers, d10s, and spare status markers near the map.
8. The scenario identifies the First Player. The other side is the Second Player for the whole war.

Starting ships require maintenance on Game Turn 1. No starting force may be placed at a neutralized World or an unconnected Outpost unless the scenario explicitly says otherwise.

[4.0] SEQUENCE OF PLAY

A war lasts no more than five Game Turns. Each Game Turn contains one joint Logistics Phase followed by a Player Turn for each side. The First Player always takes the first Player Turn.

[4.1] Game Turn Sequence

- A. **Advance the clocks.** Move the Terran Turn marker up one space and the Imperial Turn marker down one space. Do this at the start of Game Turn 1 as well.
- B. **Joint Logistics Phase.** Both sides complete these steps, First Player first when order matters:
 1. Political Events
 2. Determine Connections and Collect Income
 3. Pay Maintenance

4. Draw, Discard, and Purchase Cards
 5. Receive Completed Production
 6. Purchase New Production
- C. **First Player Turn.**
1. First Movement Phase
 2. First Combat Phase
 3. Enemy Reaction Movement Phase
 4. Enemy Reaction Combat Phase
 5. Second Movement Phase
 6. Second Combat Phase
- D. **Second Player Turn.** Repeat the six steps above with the roles reversed.
- E. **End Phase.**
1. Remove temporary markers and restore temporary Militia.
 2. Check whether unsupported neutralized Worlds recover.
 3. Apply delayed Glory changes and check for the end of the war.

[4.2] Phasing Player

The player whose Movement or Combat Phase is in progress is the **Phasing Player**. The opponent is the **Non-Phasing Player**. In a Reaction Phase, the reacting player becomes the Phasing Player for that phase only.

[4.3] Combat Phase Order

The Phasing Player chooses the order of contested systems. Completely resolve one system before beginning another. In each system:

1. resolve space combat, including any troop landings;
2. resolve bombardment, if permitted;
3. make final landings; and
4. resolve every ground combat on a surface in that system.

Combat is mandatory wherever opposing combat-capable ships occupy the same stellar hex. Ground combat is mandatory wherever opposing Ground Units occupy the same surface.

[4.4] First Player in Later Wars

In the first war Terra is the First Player. In every later war, the loser of the previous war is the First Player. The winner therefore deploys second but moves second, reflecting the loser's preparations for renewed hostilities.

[5.0] MOVEMENT AND LOGISTICS

Ships move only by jumping along printed jump routes. A jump is movement from one stellar hex directly to an adjacent stellar hex. The intervening map hexes are never entered. Movement is voluntary, and groups may split or combine as allowed by the *Space Empires: 4X* group rules.

[5.1] Refuelling

A stack may make any number of jumps in a normal Movement Phase, but after it enters a system it must refuel before it can leave that system in the same phase. A stack can refuel at:

- a friendly World or Outpost that is not neutralized;
- a friendly Fleet Train that began the phase in that system and has not moved during the phase; or
- any system, if the moving stack consists entirely of Scouts.

A stack can therefore travel rapidly down a prepared chain and make one final jump beyond it. It must then stop. A source may refuel any number of stacks. Enemy control of the stellar hex prevents refuelling there, even if a friendly surface remains below.

[5.2] Enemy-Occupied Systems

A stack stops when it enters a system containing enemy combat-capable ships. It must fight in the following Combat Phase. A stack entering a system with only enemy non-combat ships destroys those ships immediately and may continue if it can refuel. An enemy-controlled surface does not by itself stop movement.

[5.3] Supply Status

Supply is checked during the Joint Logistics Phase and lasts for the Game Turn. A ship is **supplied** if it is:

- in a system containing a connected friendly World or Outpost;
- in a system containing a friendly Fleet Train; or
- one jump from either of those locations along a jump route not blocked by enemy ships.

An unsupplied ship costs one additional RU to maintain and may make at most one jump in each Movement or Reaction Movement Phase.

Scouts ignore the movement penalty but not the maintenance surcharge. A ship that becomes supplied later in the turn does not lose its unsupplied marker until the next Logistics Phase.

[5.4] Fleet Trains

MS Pipeline counters are Fleet Trains. A Fleet Train is a non-combat ship with its printed hull and defense, a production cost of 5 RU, no maintenance cost, and a speed of one jump per Movement Phase. It may not react. It provides fuel only if it did not move in the current phase, but it provides supply during the Logistics Phase simply by being present.

Fleet Trains are automatically screened while friendly combat ships remain. They are destroyed if caught alone. A Fleet Train may bridge an empty system when tracing an economic connection.

[5.5] Fighters and Ground Units

Fighters cannot jump. They may operate at a friendly World or Outpost or be carried by Carriers under *Space Empires: 4X* section 11. A Carrier carries three Fighter groups. Fighters may transfer between a base and Carrier when the Carrier is in the same system.

Ground Units cannot jump. A Transport carries up to six Ground Units using *Close Encounters* section 14. Loading or unloading at a friendly surface does not use movement, but a particular Ground Unit may be loaded and unloaded only once in a Movement Phase.

[5.6] Reaction Movement

During a Reaction Movement Phase the reacting player may move one stack from one system. The stack may make up to its side's Reaction Allowance (two jumps for Terra and three for the Imperium at the start of the campaign), subject to refuelling, supply, and enemy-occupied-system rules. It need not move toward the Phasing Player. All groups in the chosen stack need not end together, but no additional group may begin reaction movement.

Only ships that participated in Reaction Movement may attack in the following Reaction Combat Phase. Friendly units already present in the battle system may join their combat normally. Bases and Fighters may fight if the re-

action stack ends in their system, but they do not themselves react.

Cards and technology can increase the number of reacting stacks or jumps. A reaction stack can never make more than six jumps.

[5.7] Retreat Movement

Retreat is part of combat, not a Movement Phase. A retreating group moves to one adjacent system free of enemy combat-capable ships. It need not refuel, but it may not participate again during the current Player Turn. A group with no legal destination cannot retreat.

[6.0] ECONOMICS AND PRODUCTION

[6.1] Connections

A Terran World is connected if a path can be traced from it to Sol. An Imperial World is connected if a path can be traced from it to Gashidda. Trace through jump routes and systems containing a friendly World, friendly Outpost, or friendly Fleet Train. The endpoints count, and directly adjacent friendly sites connect without an intermediate counter.

Enemy combat-capable ships block a path through their stellar hex. A neutralized site cannot carry a path. An Outpost is connected if it can trace to any connected friendly World. Several isolated Worlds may form a local network, but none of them is connected until the network reaches the capital.

Determine all connections before either player collects income; they do not change for economic purposes later in the phase.

[6.2] Income

Source	Terra	Imperium
Provincial budget	—	10
Connected World	8	3
Unconnected World	6	1
Connected Outpost	1	0
Unconnected Outpost	0	0

Neutralized Worlds and contested or enemy-held Outposts produce nothing. Income is added to saved RU. Temporary political and card effects are applied after the normal total is known.

[6.3] Maintenance

Pay maintenance for every ship already on the map. The cost of one ship is its printed Hull Size in RU, as in *Space Empires: 4X*. Fighters pay maintenance; Fleet Trains, Bases, and Ground Units do not. A Carrier and its Fighters are maintained separately. Each unsupplied ship costs one additional RU.

The owner chooses the order of payment. Any ship not maintained is scrapped immediately; reduce or remove its group. Existing damage does not reduce its cost. Ships arriving later in this Logistics Phase pay no maintenance until the next Game Turn.

[6.4] Completed Production

Move units due on the current Game Turn from the production track to the map. A ship appears at any connected friendly World. A Base or Ground Unit appears on any friendly, unneutralized World. An Outpost appears in the owner's unplaced pool and must be transported to its destination.

If no legal arrival location exists, delay the unit to the next Game Turn. A delayed unit is not lost if the war ends; it carries into the peace process.

[6.5] Purchasing Units

Pay the printed *Space Empires: 4X* or *Close Encounters* CP cost in RU. Outposts cost 4 RU and Fleet Trains cost 5 RU. A player may buy only units allowed by their current technology and available in their counter mix.

When purchasing an SC, DD, CA, BC, BB, or DN, assign its Beam, Missile, or Mixed Armament Package. A ship may join an existing group only if its type, technology, and package match that group; otherwise form a new group.

Place purchases on the Game Turn track:

- Ground Units, Fighters, Transports, Scouts, Destroyers, Cruisers, Carriers, Bases, Fleet Trains, and Outposts arrive next Game Turn.
- Battlecruisers, Battleships, and Dreadnoughts arrive two Game Turns later.

A purchase scheduled after Game Turn 5 is retained for the interwar sequence. Technology cannot be purchased during a war.

[6.6] Bases and Outposts

A Base represents fixed orbital and surface defenses. No surface may contain more than one Base. A newly arrived Base becomes operational immediately.

An unplaced Outpost is cargo and requires one Transport capacity. It may be unloaded on any empty surface. It becomes operational at the end of the owning player's Second Combat Phase if no enemy Ground Units occupy that surface. An Outpost can be placed on a neutralized enemy World to hold it without a Ground Unit; it does not produce income there.

[7.0] SPACE COMBAT

Space combat combines *Imperium's* range and weapon decisions with the *Space Empires: 4X* firing order, attack and defense values, screening, and hull damage. Every combat round occurs at either **Long Range** or **Close Range**. Missiles dominate the approach; beams become decisive after fleets close.

The two bands deliberately compress Traveller's more detailed scale. Picket ships and Tactics stand in for thrust, sensors, and fleet handling. Point defense lasers protect against missile salvos, while sandcaster reactions protect against direct-fire beams.

[7.1] Armament Packages

Every SC, DD, CA, BC, BB, and DN group has one Armament Package. Record the package on its technology row. All ships in a group must have the same package.

Package	Long Range	Close Range
Beam (B)	Cannot fire	Beam at full Attack
Missile (M)	Missile at full Attack	Missile at -1 Attack, after beams
Mixed (X)	Missile at -1 Attack	Beam at -1, or missile at -2 after beams

"Attack" in this table means the printed Attack value before technology, Fleet Size, defense, and other modifiers. A modified Hit Number of zero or less still hits on a natural 1.

Fighters have a fixed Beam Package. Bases have

a fixed Missile Package. Carriers, Transports, and Fleet Trains have no package and cannot fire if their printed Attack is zero.

Choose a package when a ship is purchased. A ship may change package only during peace, at a cost of 1 RU per Hull Size. Package identity is hidden with the group until the group is revealed.

[7.2] Prepare the Battle

Move the opposing groups off-map and mark the contested system. Reveal all ships, Armament Packages, and current technology. Arrange each side's groups by firing class.

A Base on a friendly surface in the system joins its owner's space battle. In a binary system, every friendly Base may join. A Base is combat-capable, counts for Fleet Size and screening, and cannot retreat. Ground Units and surfaces do not otherwise participate in space combat.

The player whose movement caused the battle is the attacker. If neither side moved into the system this phase, the Phasing Player is the attacker.

[7.3] Initial Range

The first round begins at Long Range. This represents missile exchanges while the opposing formations approach. A scenario or card may change the initial range.

[7.4] Range Control

Before the second and every later round, each player selects one combat-capable, non-Fighter ship as a **Picket**. A Picket still fires normally. Its Maneuver Rating is:

Ship	Maneuver
Scout	+2
Destroyer	+1
Cruiser, Carrier, or Transport	0
Battlecruiser, Battleship, or Dreadnought	-1
No eligible ship	-2

Fleet Trains and Bases cannot be Pickets. Each player rolls a d10 and adds the Picket's Maneuver Rating and friendly Tactics. The side with fewer combat-capable non-Fighter ships also adds +1. The higher total chooses Long or Close Range for the round. On a tie, range remains unchanged.

This roll replaces *Imperium's* range-determination roll and Traveller's individual thrust accounting. Destroying an enemy Scout can therefore change control of the engagement.

[7.5] Screening and Fleet Size

After establishing range each round, count combat-capable ships, including operational Fighters and Bases. The side with more may screen eligible groups under *Space Empires: 4X* rule 5.7. Fleet Trains and other non-combat units are screened automatically while a friendly combat-capable ship remains.

If one side has at least twice as many unscreened combat-capable ships as the other, it receives the normal Fleet Size Bonus of +1 Attack for that firing round. Recalculate range control, screening, and Fleet Size every round.

[7.6] Defensive Reactions

Defensive reactions are declared after screening and before any ship fires.

[7.6.1] Point Defense

At Point Defense 1 or higher, an unscreened SC or DD with a Beam or Mixed Package may escort one friendly target group. The escort forfeits all offensive fire and Close Assaults this round. The protected group gains +1 Defense against missiles, increased to +2 at Point Defense 2 or 3. A target group may have only one escort. If the escort is destroyed before a missile attack, the bonus is lost.

At Point Defense 3, the escort may also make one normal attack at -1 Attack. This is an exception to forfeiting offensive fire. Point defense represents laser interception, electronic warfare, and terminal countermeasures against an incoming salvo.

[7.6.2] Disperse Sand

Any non-Fighter combat ship may disperse sand. It forfeits all offensive fire, Close Assaults, and point defense this round, but gains +1 Defense against every beam attack for the round. Sand has no effect against missiles. A ship that has already fired cannot disperse sand.

[7.7] Firing Order

At **Long Range**, resolve missile fire from Class A through E. Beam-only ships cannot fire.

At **Close Range**, first resolve all beam fire from Class A through E. Then resolve short-range missile fire from Class A through E. A ship may fire only once in the round; a Mixed ship must choose beam or missile fire. A ship destroyed by beam fire cannot later make a short-range missile attack.

Within the same class and weapon step, higher Tactics fires first. The defender fires first if Tactics is tied. Fire is not simultaneous. A destroyed ship does not fire later in the round.

Each surviving firing ship may target any unscreened enemy unit. A group's ships may choose different targets, and the owner may observe each die before choosing the next target.

[7.8] Fire Resolution

Start with the Attack value after its Armament Package modifier, then calculate:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Hit Number} &= \text{Attack} + \text{Attack Tech} + \text{Fleet Bonus} \\ &\quad - \text{target Defense} - \text{target Defense Tech} \\ &\quad - \text{defensive reaction bonuses} \end{aligned}$$

Roll a d10. A result equal to or less than the Hit Number scores one hit. A natural 1 always hits. Technology added to a particular ship may not exceed that ship's Hull Size. Package, card, and combat-option modifiers are applied after enforcing that technology limit.

Damage is cumulative. When a ship has hits equal to its Hull Size, remove it and reduce its group's numeral. Carry surviving damage out of combat; it may be repaired in a later Logistics Phase.

[7.9] Missile Options

[7.9.1] High-Intensity Missile Fire

A ship making a missile attack at either range may expend its magazines for +1 Attack. Mark it Missile Depleted after firing. It cannot make another missile attack during the current Combat Phase. A Mixed ship may still fire beams in a later round.

High-Intensity Fire is declared separately for each ship when it fires. A ship that is retreating or performing point defense cannot use it.

[7.9.2] Short-Range Missile Fire

At Close Range, Missile ships attack at -1 and Mixed ships at -2. These attacks occur only after every beam class has fired. High-Intensity Fire may be combined with short-range missile fire.

[7.10] Close Assault

At Close Range, a SC, DD, or Fighter making a beam attack may declare a Close Assault. Before the attacker rolls, its target may make immediate defensive beam fire if it has a Beam or Mixed Package and has not fired, retreated, or used a defensive reaction this round. This defensive shot expends the target's normal fire.

If the assaulting ship survives, it attacks with +1 Attack. If defensive fire destroys it, it is removed before it can fire. This replaces *Imperium's* Suicide Attack while retaining its risk-and-reward role.

[7.11] Fighters and Carriers

Use *Space Empires: 4X* section 11 except as changed here. Fighters use Beam fire and may conduct Close Assaults; they cannot fire at Long Range. Fighters in a system require enough friendly Carrier capacity or a friendly unneutralized World or Outpost. Excess Fighters are destroyed when their final base or carrying capacity is lost.

[7.12] Landing During a Space Battle

After the first firing round, either side may land carried Space Marines on a surface in the system. After the second and each later round, either side may land any carried Ground Units. The attacker announces first each round.

A Transport may land units even if screened. Space combat then continues. Ground combat waits until space combat in the system is complete. A player may therefore win on the ground after losing in orbit, but surviving enemy ships may attack their Transports before the space battle ends.

[7.13] Retreat

Beginning in the second firing round, a group may retreat instead of firing when its printed class is reached in the applicable weapon step. A group with no usable weapon at the current range may still retreat at its printed class. Move it to one legal adjacent system. Carriers may not

abandon excess Fighters. Bases, Fleet Trains, and other non-combat units cannot retreat.

Combat ends when only one side has combat-capable ships in the stellar hex. Destroy all enemy non-combat ships left with no escort. Remove Missile Depleted and defensive-reaction markers at the end of the Combat Phase.

[7.14] Repair

During Maintenance, remove damage from ships at a connected friendly World by paying 1 RU per hit. Damage at any other location cannot be repaired. Repair is optional and occurs after normal maintenance; a damaged ship that is scrapped needs no repair.

[8.0] PLANETARY OPERATIONS

Worlds cannot be conquered by bombardment alone. Fleets suppress local forces; Ground Units seize and hold the surface.

[8.1] Ground Units and Technology

Infantry, Space Marines, Heavy Infantry, Militia, and Grav Armor use their printed *Close Encounters* class, attack, defense, and hull values. They require no maintenance. Ground Combat 2 is required for Space Marines and Heavy Infantry; Ground Combat 3 is required for Grav Armor and Drop Ships.

Space Marines represent Traveller jump troops. They may land after the first space-combat round and always fire normally in the first ground-combat round. Other troops may land after the second space round. Without Ground Combat 3, non-Marine attackers landed from Transports do not fire in the first ground round. With Ground Combat 3, Drop Ships allow them to fire normally.

[8.2] Militia

When a surface is bombarded or invaded, place temporary defending Militia:

Surface	Militia
Outpost	1
World	5
Sol or Gashidda	8
Neutralized World	0

Militia are in addition to permanent Ground

Units. Remove surviving Militia after combat in that system; a later invasion generates the full amount again. Bombardment losses reduce Militia only for an invasion made in the same Combat Phase.

[8.3] Bombardment

After space combat, the side controlling the stellar hex may bombard one enemy surface if it has not landed Ground Units on that surface in this Combat Phase. It may stop bombarding and land at any time; bombardment cannot resume that phase.

Place Militia, then fire eligible ships one at a time using normal space fire resolution. Fleet Size and Tactics do not apply. The surface has Defense 0, increased to 1 if it contains one to three permanent Ground Units or to 2 if it contains four or more. Each hit removes one Militia. Bombardment cannot hit permanent Ground Units, a World, or an Outpost.

Fighters, Transports, Fleet Trains, and ships with printed Attack 0 cannot bombard. A natural 1 always hits.

[8.4] Final Landing

After bombardment, the orbital victor may land carried Ground Units. Units that landed during the space battle remain on the surface. Ground Units may also unload on an uncontested friendly surface without combat.

If opposing Ground Units are present, resolve ground combat even if the invader's fleet lost or retreated from the system.

[8.5] Ground Combat Procedure

At the start of every round, the side with more firing Ground Units may screen eligible units as in space combat. Resolve fire by printed class from A through E. Tactics, ship technologies, and Fleet Size do not apply. The defender fires first when class is tied.

Fire resolution is otherwise identical to space combat: Attack minus target Defense is the Hit Number, a d10 result at or below it hits, and a natural 1 always hits. Damage equal to Hull Size destroys the unit. Apply Grav Armor support under *Close Encounters* rule 14.11.

Ground combat continues until one side has no

Ground Units. There is no ground retreat. Bases are not Ground Units and do not fire in ground combat.

[8.6] Conquest

If the defender wins, remove surviving Militia and all current bombardment effects. If the attacker wins, remove one surviving attacking Ground Unit as the cost of establishing an occupation, then apply the result below. This unit does not count as a remaining garrison; another Ground Unit or an Outpost must hold a neutralized World. If the attacker cannot or will not pay the occupation cost, the surface is not conquered and returns to its prior owner.

- **Outpost:** replace it with an attacker's Outpost. Destroy any Base on the surface.
- **World:** place a Neutralized marker. The World produces no RU, carries no connection, bases no Fighters, and creates no Militia.
- **Capital:** neutralizing Sol or Gashidda ends the campaign immediately.

A non-capital World stays neutralized while an enemy Ground Unit or enemy Outpost remains on it. If neither is present in the End Phase, remove the Neutralized marker and restore its original owner. A friendly conquest of a previously neutralized World removes the marker immediately.

[9.0] TECHNOLOGY

Technology is strategic, not tactical procurement. It never changes during a war. Every eligible friendly ship uses the side's current level; there is no need to record different generations of the same ship group.

[9.1] Available Fields

Field	Terra	Imperium	Max
Attack	0	0	2
Defense	0	0	2
Tactics	0	1	2
Fighter	1	1	3
Point Defense	1	1	3
Ground Combat	2	2	3
Capital Construction	0	1	3
Reaction Command	0	1	1

Attack and Defense add their level to eligible ship values. Tactics modifies Range Control and

breaks same-class firing ties. Fighter uses the printed *Space Empires: 4X* rules; Point Defense uses the defensive-reaction rule in Space Combat. Ground Combat 3 unlocks Grav Armor and Drop Ships. Reaction Allowance equals two plus Reaction Command.

Attack and Defense bonuses on a particular ship remain limited by its Hull Size. Fighter effects follow *Space Empires: 4X* even when their level exceeds a small ship's hull; only their explicit eligible targets gain the benefit.

Capital Construction 0 permits ships through CA and CV. Level 1 adds BC, level 2 adds BB, and level 3 adds DN. Titans are never available in the core campaign.

[9.2] Excluded Fields

Movement, Ship Yard, Exploration, Terraforming, Cloaking, Scanner, Mine, Boarding, and Titan technologies are not used. Printed movement levels are replaced by jump-route movement and refuelling. A card called Minefield does not unlock or require Mine technology.

[9.3] Interwar Development

During each peace, both sides receive Development Points (DP): one DP, plus one for every three full turns of peace, plus one additional DP for the loser of the preceding war. Unspent DP carry forward.

Raising a field one level costs 1 DP. Raising Attack or Defense to level 2, or Capital Construction to level 3, costs 2 DP. A field may be raised only once during a particular peace. New levels apply to all eligible units at the start of the next war.

This is the only normal way to improve technology. A political result that would grant technology during a war instead grants 10 RU or accelerates one unit under construction by one Game Turn, owner's choice.

[10.0] POLITICS, GLORY, AND VICTORY

[10.1] Senate Intervention

At the start of the Terran part of the Joint Logistics Phase, roll 2d6:

Roll	Result
2	Political interference: the Imperial player chooses one Terran stack; it can make only one jump in each normal Movement Phase this turn.
3–4	Cutbacks: lose 5 RU after collecting income.
5–9	No effect.
10–11	Appropriation: gain 5 RU.
12	Emergency mobilization: gain 10 RU and draw one card. Increase Glory by 1: the Imperial court takes the Terran threat more seriously.

Losses cannot reduce saved RU below zero.

[10.2] Imperial Intervention

Roll 2d6 and modify it by the current Glory Index: –2 at Glory 1–2, –1 at 3–4, no modifier at 5–6, +1 at 7–8, and +2 at 9–10. Regardless of the modifier, a natural total of 10 draws one card after resolving the table.

Modified roll	Result
2 or less	Depression: the provincial budget produces 5 fewer RU this turn; discard one random card.
3	Depression: the provincial budget produces 5 fewer RU this turn.
4	Boom: the provincial budget produces 5 additional RU this turn.
5	Imperial succession: set Glory to 5 after all current Glory changes, then shuffle the discard pile into the deck.
6–7	No effect.
8	Imperial attention: draw one card.
9–10	No effect.
11	Frontier crisis: pay 5 RU or decrease Glory by 1.
12	Token reinforcements: gain 5 RU.
13	Reinforcements: gain 10 RU.
14	Mandated offensive: gain 10 RU. If no Imperial ship enters a Terran-controlled system this Game Turn, decrease Glory by 1 in the End Phase.
15 or more	Recentralization: lose 10 RU and discard two cards.

Political income and losses are applied after normal income is collected.

[10.3] Appeal to the Emperor

After Imperial Intervention, the Imperial player may make one Appeal. Decrease Glory by 1, then roll 2d6:

Roll	Result
2–4	Denied; no further effect.
5–7	Gain 5 RU. On a natural 6, also draw one card.
8–9	Gain 10 RU.
10–11	Move one unit under construction one Game Turn closer.
12	Gain 15 RU or move two units one Game Turn closer.

An Appeal cannot be made at Glory 1. An accelerated unit due now arrives in the Completed Production step of the same phase.

[10.4] Glory Changes

Glory measures the Imperial governor's reputation. Keep it between 1 and 10. Only the Imperial perspective is scored:

Event	Glory
Imperium captures a Terran Outpost	+1
Terra captures an Imperial Outpost	–1
Imperium neutralizes a Terran World	+4
Terra neutralizes an Imperial World	–4
Original owner recaptures a site	reverse its prior change

Record changes immediately. A site cannot be farmed for Glory: its net change at any time is determined by its status relative to the start of the war.

[10.5] Ending a War

In every End Phase compare the Turn markers with Glory. Terra wins the war if the Terran Turn marker is equal to or greater than Glory. The Imperium wins if the Imperial Turn marker is equal to or less than Glory. Only one condition can be true in a given End Phase. With Glory unchanged at 5, Terra wins at the end of Game Turn 5.

Neutralizing the enemy capital ends the entire campaign immediately, regardless of Glory. Otherwise the war winner is determined by the Glory clock and play continues through the peace sequence.

[11.0] WARS AND PEACE

A full campaign is a sequence of wars. Use the following steps after a war ends unless playing a stand-alone scenario.

[11.1] Length of Peace

Each player secretly chooses a number from 1 to 6, then reveal together. Add the choices and subtract one; the result is the number of peace turns. A long peace permits more development and production but exposes older fleets to more attrition.

[11.2] Peace Sequence

1. **Record the result.** Note the winner, ending Glory, territory, saved RU, delayed production, and technology.
2. **Repatriate mobile forces.** Remove ships and Ground Units from the map, keeping damage. They will redeploy in step 10. Worlds, Outposts, Bases, and Fleet Trains remain in place.
3. **Take reparations.** The winner may place two free Outposts on empty surfaces adjacent to a friendly World or Outpost, or may replace one enemy Outpost adjacent to a friendly site with a friendly Outpost.
4. **Settle territory.** A neutralized World without an enemy Outpost returns to its original owner. For a non-capital World with an enemy Outpost, roll a d10. If the result is equal to or less than the peace length, replace the original World with the occupier's World; otherwise it remains neutralized into the next war. A capital never changes ownership this way.
5. **Collect interwar income.** Each player collects one normal turn of income using the newly settled territory. No political event occurs and no ship maintenance is paid.
6. **Complete old production.** Every peace turn advances existing production one space. Completed units enter the owner's force pool.
7. **Apply attrition.** Roll a d10 for every surviving ship that was not completed during this peace. If the roll is equal to or less than the

peace length minus two, the ship suffers one hit. The owner may prevent a roll by paying RU equal to the ship's Hull Size. Destroy ships that reach their Hull Size.

8. **Develop technology.** Receive and spend DP under section 9.
9. **Build forces.** Spend remaining RU on any currently legal unit. These units are complete for the next war; there is no production delay. Outposts cost only 2 RU during peace.
10. **Redeploy.** The loser deploys all repatriated ships and Ground Units first, then the winner. A unit may deploy at any friendly, unneutralized World or connected Outpost. Repair all surviving damage at no cost.
11. **Prepare the next war.** Discard or cash in cards, calculate new starting hands, reset Glory to 5 and the Turn markers to 0 and 11. The loser of the preceding war becomes First Player.

Outposts placed in a primary surface box do not automatically become Worlds; only conquest and a future scenario rule can change World ownership.

[12.0] THE IMPERIUM DECK

The shared 42-card deck represents intelligence, political favors, operational plans, and friction. Keep hands secret. The manifest below is authoritative; card faces abbreviate these clarifications where space requires.

[12.1] Starting Hands

At the start of a war, Terra draws one card per friendly controlled World. The Imperium draws one card per two friendly controlled Worlds, rounded up. This is that side's **minimum hand size** for the war. In *First Shots*, Terra begins with three cards and the Imperium with two.

The hand limit is the number of connected friendly Worlds and Outposts. If a player exceeds it, discard immediately to the limit. A minimum hand size never forces a hand above its current limit.

[12.2] Card Step

In the Draw, Discard, and Purchase Cards step, draw until reaching the minimum hand size. Then a player may discard unwanted cards for 1 RU each and buy cards for 5 RU each. Dis-

cards happen before purchases. A purchased card cannot be discarded in the same Logistics Phase.

When the deck is empty, shuffle the face-up discard pile to form a new deck. If a card instructs an earlier reshuffle, include that card unless stated otherwise.

[12.3] Playing Cards

A card can be played only at its listed timing. Each player may play at most one card in a particular phase or combat substep. The attacker declares a card first in combat; the First Player declares first at other shared timings. If effects conflict, resolve the card played later after applying prohibitions.

After resolving a card, discard it face up. A player must satisfy every stated requirement. Effects that choose “ships” choose individual ships even when a numeral marker represents several ships in one group.

[12.4] Between Wars

Cards do not carry into the next war. For each card left in hand, choose one: gain 3 RU for interwar production, or prevent one ship’s attrition roll. Two cards are required to protect a BB or DN. Then discard all hands and calculate new starting hands after deployment.

[12.5] Card Manifest

[12.5.1] A Call to Arms (2)

Combat — start of the second firing round. Ships from one adjacent system may enter this battle. At least one of your original combat-capable ships must have survived round one. Bases cannot move; Fighters require Carrier capacity. The reinforcements did not move for purposes of later reaction eligibility.

[12.5.2] Close the Range (2)

Space Combat — before the first firing round. The first firing round is at Close Range instead of Long Range. Resolve beam fire first, then short-range missile fire with its normal penalties.

[12.5.3] Commandos (2)

Planetary Operations — when landing. Move up to three Infantry from one friendly surface in an adjacent system directly to the invaded surface. They require no Transport and may fire in

the first ground round.

[12.5.4] Confused Fighting (1)

Space Combat — before first-round screening. Skip Range Control for this battle. When each ship fires, treat the range as optimal for its chosen weapon: Beam and Missile Packages use full Attack, while a Mixed Package uses –1. Resolve beam classes A–E and then missile classes A–E, regardless of the current band. This affects both sides. After every combat in the current Combat Phase is complete, shuffle the discard pile into the deck.

[12.5.5] Direct Hit (2)

Space Combat — after rolling. Change one of your attack dice to a natural 1. Then draw one card. The die must have been part of a legal attack.

[12.5.6] Economic Boom (2)

Logistics — after connections are determined. Each connected friendly Outpost produces one additional RU this turn. The Imperial player may instead cancel a Depression result before its RU or card loss is applied.

[12.5.7] Electronic Warfare (2)

Space Combat — after groups are revealed. Choose up to three enemy groups. In the first firing round, each chosen group fires one class later (Class E remains E).

[12.5.8] Escape Plan (1)

Combat — before a firing round. Retreat every one of your ships from the battle to the same legal adjacent system without enemy fire. If you retreat from a friendly World, adjust Glory one point in the opponent’s favor: –1 for an Imperial retreat or +1 for a Terran retreat.

[12.5.9] Flank Speed (2)

Reaction Movement. One reacting stack may make three more jumps than its current Reaction Allowance, to a maximum of six. Refuelling and enemy interception still apply.

[12.5.10] Intel (2)

Any time except combat. Look at the opponent’s hand, choose one card, and discard it.

[12.5.11] Logistics (2)

Logistics — before maintenance. Gain 5 RU. One friendly stack is treated as supplied

for maintenance and movement throughout this Game Turn.

[12.5.12] Mass Drivers (2)

Bombardment. Before normal bombardment, make one bonus Attack 7 against the surface. Apply its Defense but no ship technology or Fleet Size. On a hit, remove one Militia.

[12.5.13] Minefield (2)

Space Combat — before defensive reactions. Play only in a system containing a friendly World or Outpost. Randomly select two enemy ships, or every enemy ship if fewer than two are present. After reactions are declared, make a separate Missile Attack 5 against each, subtracting its normal Defense, Defense Tech, and Point Defense. Each hit causes one damage.

[12.5.14] Overrun (1)

Immediately after Space Combat. If every enemy ship was destroyed or retreated, one victorious stack may make one jump. Resolve any new battle immediately. The stack cannot refuel during this jump and Fleet Trains cannot take part.

[12.5.15] Queued Up (2)

Reaction Movement. Move up to three reacting stacks instead of one. Each uses the normal Reaction Allowance and all usual restrictions.

[12.5.16] Reckless Attack (2)

Combat — before one firing round. As each of your ships fires, you may give it +2 Attack for that shot. Until the end of the round, enemy attacks against that ship receive +1 Attack. Mark participating ships as necessary.

[12.5.17] Resistance (2)

Ground Combat — before the first round. Every defending permanent Ground Unit receives +1 Attack and +1 Defense in the first two rounds. Militia receive +1 Attack only.

[12.5.18] Sabotage (1)

Immediately after enemy production. Choose an enemy ship group in a system containing an enemy Outpost adjacent to one of your Worlds or Outposts. Roll a d10; on 1–7, the group suffers one hit allocated by its owner. Then shuffle the entire discard pile, including this card, into the deck.

[12.5.19] Snafu (2)

Start of an enemy Player Turn. Choose one system containing an enemy Outpost. Enemy stacks that begin a normal Movement Phase there may make no more than two jumps in that phase.

[12.5.20] Standoff (2)

Space Combat — before the first firing round. If both sides have a combat-capable ship after round one, combat ends. The attacker retreats all ships first, then the defender; no retreat fire occurs. A ship with no legal destination remains in the system.

[12.5.21] Supply Run (2)

Start of your Movement Phase. One stack ignores its supply movement penalty and need not refuel for its first three jumps this phase. Enemy ships still stop it.

[12.5.22] Surprise (2)

Space Combat — before the first firing round. Choose Long or Close Range for each of the first two firing rounds. Skip Range Control before round two. If opposing range-setting cards conflict, the defender chooses the range for round one and the attacker chooses it for round two.

[12.5.23] Tactics (2)

Space Combat — before the first firing round. Treat your Tactics as one level higher for Range Control and firing-order ties in this battle. Once in each firing round, reroll one of your attack dice; the new result is final.

[13.0] SCENARIO: FIRST SHOTS

The First Interstellar War begins in AD 2113. This scenario is the recommended first playtest and can be played as a stand-alone war or the opening of a campaign.

[13.1] Common Setup

Use the full *Imperium* map. Set Glory to 5, both RU totals to 0, and use the starting technologies in section 9. Terra deploys first and is the First Player. Each listed ship is one ship; combine identical ships into groups as desired.

[13.2] Terra

Place Worlds at Sol, Alpha Centauri A, and Alpha Centauri B. Place Outposts at Junction,

Barnard's Star, and Proxima Centauri; keep three additional Outposts unplaced. Place two Bases on any Terran Worlds.

Deploy the following at any Terran World or placed Outpost:

- 3 Beam Scouts, 2 Mixed Destroyers, 1 Beam Cruiser, and 1 Carrier;
- 2 Fighters, 2 Transports, and 1 Fleet Train; and
- 3 Infantry and 1 Space Marine.

Terra begins at Capital Construction 0 and Reaction Command 0; its other technology is shown in section 9. Draw three cards.

[13.3] The Imperium

Place Worlds at Dingir, Gashidda, Ishkur, and Nusku. Place Outposts at Agidda, Apishal, Enki Kalamma, Shulgi, Shulgili, Shuruppak, and Zaggisi. Place three Bases on any Imperial Worlds.

Deploy the following at any Imperial World or Outpost:

- 2 Mixed Scouts, 3 Mixed Destroyers, 2 Mixed Cruisers, and 1 Missile Battlecruiser;
- 1 Carrier, 2 Fighters, 1 Transport, and 1 Fleet Train; and
- 3 Infantry, 1 Heavy Infantry, and 1 Space Marine.

The Imperium begins at Capital Construction 1, Tactics 1, and Reaction Command 1; its other technology is shown in section 9. Draw two cards.

[13.4] Scenario End

Use the normal Glory clock. If playing stand-alone, the side that wins the war wins the scenario. If playing a campaign, proceed immediately to Wars and Peace. Neutralizing Sol or Gashidda wins the campaign at once.

[13.5] First-Play Simplifications

For the first learning game, omit political rolls and Appeals, give each side 5 extra RU on Game Turn 1, and play with hands revealed. Use every other rule. This produces a cleaner test of movement, combat, and the force balance before adding political variance.

[14.0] PLAYER AID

[14.1] Game Turn

- A Advance Terran marker up 1; Imperial marker down 1.
- B Joint Logistics: politics, connections/income, maintenance, cards, arrivals, purchases.
- C First Player: Move, Combat, enemy Reaction Move/Combat, Move, Combat.
- D Second Player repeats the same sequence.
- E Clear temporary effects, recover unsupported Worlds, apply delayed Glory, check victory.

[14.2] Economy and Supply

Income source	Terra	Imperium
Budget	0	10
Connected World	8	3
Unconnected World	6	1
Connected Outpost	1	0

Connection paths run through friendly Worlds, Outposts, and Fleet Trains; enemy combat ships and neutralized sites block them. Ship maintenance equals Hull Size per ship. Unsupplied ships cost +1 RU and move at most one jump per Movement/Reaction Phase. Repair at a connected World for 1 RU per hit.

[14.3] Movement

A normal stack has unlimited jumps but must refuel before leaving each entered system. Friendly Worlds, Outposts, and stationary Fleet Trains refuel; all-Scout stacks self-refuel. Enemy combat ships stop movement. Reaction moves one stack up to the side's allowance (Terra 2, Imperium 3 initially). Fighters need a base or Carrier; Transports carry six Ground Units.

[14.4] Space Combat

Package	Long Range	Close Range
Beam	—	Beam full
Missile	Missile full	Missile -1, after beams
Mixed	Missile -1	Beam -1 or missile -2

1. Reveal groups, packages, and technology. Friendly Bases join.
2. Round 1 is Long. In later rounds, both sides roll d10 + Picket + Tactics; the smaller non-Fighter fleet adds +1. High side chooses range; a tie retains it. Then screen; 2:1 unscreened ships earns +1 Attack.
3. Picket: SC +2, DD +1, CA/CV/TR 0, BC/BB/DN -1, none -2.
4. Declare reactions. A Beam/Mixed SC or DD es-

cort forfeits fire to give one group +1 Defense vs missiles (+2 at Point Defense 2+). A ship may forfeit fire to gain +1 Defense vs beams by dispersing sand.

5. Long: missiles A-E. Close: beams A-E, then short missiles A-E. Higher Tactics wins class ties; defender wins remaining ties.
6. Hit Number = package-adjusted Attack + Attack Tech + Fleet Bonus - Defense - Defense Tech - reactions. Roll d10 at or below; a natural 1 always hits. Hull Size hits destroy a ship.
7. A missile ship may gain +1 Attack, then is Missile Depleted for the Combat Phase. At Close Range, an SC, DD, or Fighter may risk defensive beam fire to make a +1 Attack Close Assault.
8. From round 2, a group may retreat instead of firing at its class.

Space Marines may land after space round one; all Ground Units after round two.

[14.5] Planetary Operations

Outpost/World/Capital generates 1/5/8 Militia. Orbital victor may bombard before landing; each hit removes one Militia for this Combat Phase only. Permanent Ground Units give surface Defense 1 (one-three units) or 2 (four or more).

Ground combat uses printed Attack, Defense, Hull, and firing class. Defender fires first on class ties. No Tactics or Fleet Size. No retreat. Remove one surviving attacker to occupy: replace a captured Outpost or neutralize a World. Another Ground Unit or enemy Outpost must remain to hold a neutralized World.

[14.6] Glory Clock

Imperial capture/loss of an Outpost changes Glory +1/ - 1; neutralizing a World changes it +4/ - 4. In the End Phase, Terra wins the war if its rising Turn marker reaches Glory; the Imperium wins if its falling marker reaches Glory. Capital neutralization wins the campaign immediately.

[14.7] Technology Limits

In-war research is prohibited. Interwar DP improve Attack, Defense, Tactics, Fighter, Point Defense, Ground Combat, Capital Construction, or Reaction Command. Capital Construction 0/1/2/3 allows CA/BC/BB/DN respectively.